

BLUE WATER SHIPPING

The Engine

A package for the working days — the strategy, two concepts, and the website. One deck, four chapters, one ask at the end.

CONFIDENTIAL · September 22, 2026 · a starting point for discussion

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Four chapters and one ask

1	The Engine Pause, reset, strategy, plan	Email, FileMaker, accounting and the reports are one machine at an inflection point. The case for stopping long enough to plan — with seven weeks of mail and two reconstructed cases as evidence — and what the pause, the reset and three working days produce.
2	Agency Platform The port call as the pipeline	A concept for the port-call record the audit found missing: eight stages from nomination to settlement, with port operations, accounting and forwarding as parallel tracks.
3	BlueIQ One place for all data, all reports	The reports as a product — direction B made concrete. A proven pipeline, re-pointed at Blue Water's own data and Blue Water's own reports.
4	Website & Portal A first read, and what to review	bluewatershipping.com and the Pilotsheet portal from the outside: what is there, what the security scan says, the customer-access question, and a concept direction for a separate session.
Closing: what this needs — from the three of us, and from ownership.		

Each chapter stands on its own and can be presented separately; the page numbers run through the package.

CHAPTER 1

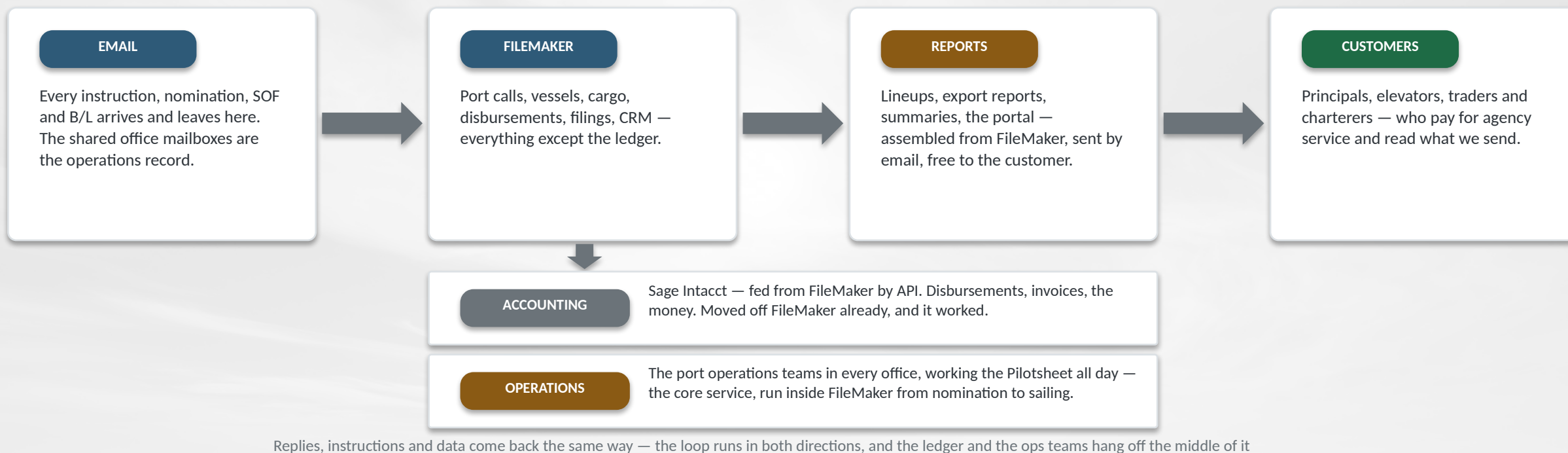
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The Engine

Pause, reset, strategy, plan

Email, FileMaker, accounting and the reports are one machine at an inflection point. The case for stopping long enough to plan — with seven weeks of mail and two reconstructed cases as evidence — and what the pause, the reset and three working days produce.

Two systems, the people, the output, the books — one machine



Outside relationships and the skill of the agents on the dock, this is how the company shows what it knows

Agency is people and relationships; the engine is how those people work and what they hand the customer. The reports, free to the customer, are the shop window — the visible proof of experience. Built in-house, it works, and it was an advantage. The question is whether it still is, and what it costs.

Why working on them in silos has not worked

Change email

...and the shared operations mailboxes, the report distribution list, the attachments FileMaker links to, and the archive the P&I club will one day ask for all change with it

Change FileMaker

...and every report's source data, the Intacct feed, the sailing-message templates that go out by email, and the customer portal change with it

Change the reports

...and the data they need from FileMaker, the delivery path through email, and what the customer expects to receive change with it

What is happening today

Four folders, four board lanes, three separate assessments, one person. Silos — and inside the FileMaker silo, sub-silos: a feature request, a data fix and a plugin upgrade all “in progress” at once. Piecemeal, each piece reasonable, and the person carrying it and the wider organisation cannot sustain it.

What follows from it

There cannot be an email decision, a FileMaker decision, an accounting decision and a reports decision. There is one decision about the engine, taken at a higher altitude with all of it in view — then the ground-level targets can be struck tactically and efficiently. That is why this deck asks for a pause rather than a platform.

Seven weeks of IT mail, measured

452

messages · 154 threads · 30 Jul – 21 Sep · one mailbox

5.5%

of messages are genuine user-facing faults — 9 of the 50 help-desk threads

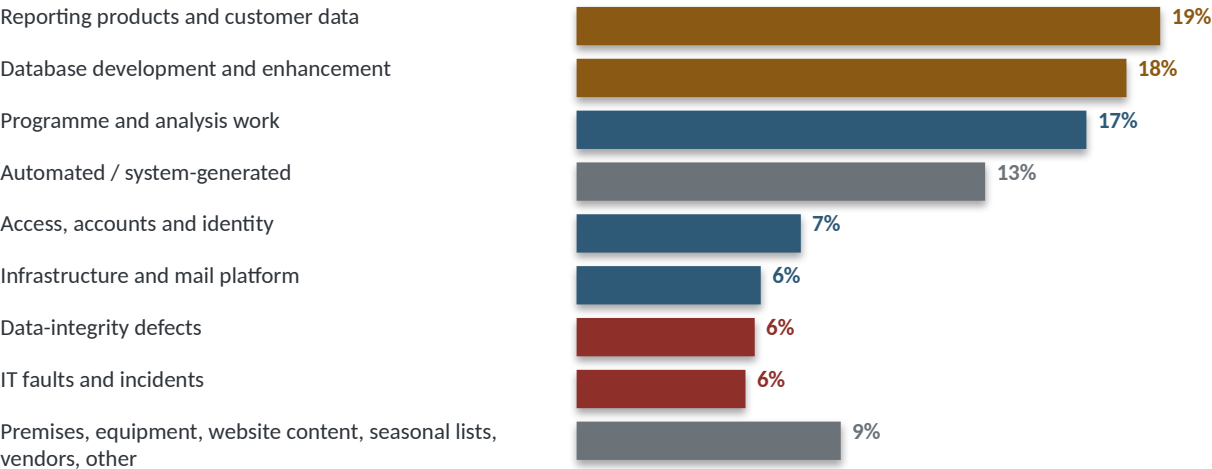
6.2

messages and 5.2 parties per development thread — the heaviest work by every proxy

9 days

median to close a seasonal gift-list edit, against 0.2 hours for a fault

Where the messages went — share of 452, by the thread's originating request

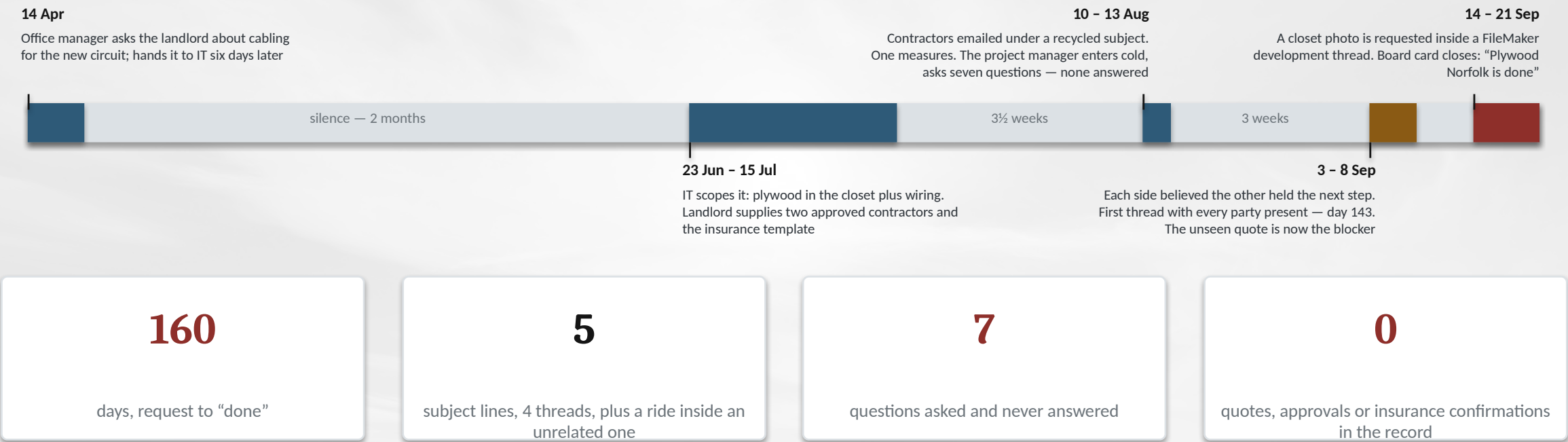


What it says

- The load is building and reporting, not fixing. Faults are the smallest human category.
- A third of the help-desk queue needs no IT judgement or is machine-generated: tariff edits, gift lists, board notices, backup alerts.
- The lightest-value work is the slowest to close — the chasing pattern, measured.
- Every share is a floor: one mailbox, what the project manager was copied on. The help-desk mailbox itself is not yet connected.

Corpus built read-only from davis@bluewatershipping.com (INBOX/IT + INBOX/Reports), classified thread by thread against a written rule set. Shares ±3–4 points; volumes, not time; no trend possible from 7½ weeks.

One sheet of plywood: 160 days, five subject lines



What the photo shows. The plywood is up — a full sheet, not the 3 × 2 specified. The network equipment it was meant to carry was never moved onto it. The board entry is true of the plywood and false of the job. Nobody did anything wrong here: effort was real on every side. No single place held the matter, so it fell between people three times and was closed by a card nobody reconciled against the work.

Reconstructed from the mail corpus; April–July recovered from quoted history inside later messages. One mailbox — correspondence the project manager was not copied on is invisible.

Two FileMaker jobs, eight threads, closed with one word

One intent, recorded as two jobs

Stop the Pilotsheet depending on what a person remembers to type: look up a vessel's particulars from a register keyed on IMO, and pick the agency service from a controlled list that maps to the ledger. Requested nine days apart, run by the same two people, estimated together to ownership in one message (about 14 programming hours), and signed off together on 21 September with one word: "Yes". Neither job sheet mentions the other.

Where the matter actually lived

- File Maker | Ships Register** — job 2's origin, and the answer to its 'blocking' question
- Freight Forwarding ... Drop Down** — job 1's origin; the ledger-dependency dispute
- Lists** — job 1 resolved; the code table; a revert proposal
- Missing Categories** — the backfill list (~40 vessels); never returned to
- Agency Service ... / Ships Register** — both jobs' hour estimates, one message
- Ships register auto fill** — job 2 executed; job 1 signed off; the plywood photo

36

days, first request to "Yes"

26

days a blocking question stood answered in the mail while the job stood 'Blocked'

4+

hand-offs to the phone — decisions taken there are invisible to the record

~40

vessels left without a category — the backfill flagged, quantified, never done

What "Yes" covered. An IMO lookup populating one layout, and a drop-down offered for review — both real, both below the written scope. Two representation changes visible in the sign-off screenshots went unremarked; a field was descoped back to free text in passing; a revert proposal was never withdrawn. Both sheets were stale by three to five weeks.

Reconstructed from the mail corpus and reconciled against the two job sheets. No assessment of any individual's performance is offered or implied.

The mechanics, from the two cases and the corpus

No single place holds a matter

Seen: Five subject lines for one sheet of plywood; eight threads for one FileMaker intent; a facilities item finishing inside a development thread.

Cost: Each hop drops context — seven questions died with a forked thread — and no subject line retrieves the matter afterwards.

Nobody holds the next step

Seen: Three silences of 2 months, 3½ weeks and 3 weeks; two ownership vacuums; 'they are waiting on you' / 'who is they?'

Cost: Elapsed time is the cost. 160 days for a morning's work; 26 days with a blocker's answer sitting unread in the mail.

The list and the queue are different things

Seen: The two hardest 'drop everything' interrupts were not on the numbered priority list; a platform migration was added, then parked in 13 days.

Cost: Capacity planned from the list understates the load. A two-hour task interrupted four times takes a day.

Closure by assertion

Seen: A board card reads 'done' against work not done; one "Yes" closes two jobs below their written scope; a backfill of ~40 records is flagged and never run.

Cost: Rework arrives later, unbudgeted, wearing a new subject line — and the reports built on the data inherit the gap.

Decisions leave no record

Seen: At least four hand-offs to the phone in one case; a revert proposal never withdrawn; sheets three to five weeks stale.

Cost: The next person — or the same person a month later — starts from zero. Key-person risk, manufactured daily.

The queue is a workshop, not a help desk

Seen: Faults are 5.5% of messages; development, reporting and programme work are over half; a third of help-desk threads need no IT judgement.

Cost: Running a workshop through a help-desk inbox means every build is an interrupt and every interrupt looks like a build.

None of this is effort or ability. It is the absence of an operating model — one door, one owner per matter, exit conditions, written decisions, verified closure. That is what the reset installs.

Evidence: the classified corpus (154 threads) and the two case reconstructions. Time figures are elapsed days from the record, never estimated minutes.

Three assessments are finished — and they agree

EMAIL

Case for change, Rev 5 · memos 008, 012, 013

- Self-hosted server on end-of-life consumer hardware, internet-facing
- POP leaves the only copy of mail on laptops — some at 2 TB; no setting can stop it
- No archive, retention or legal hold; gateway rejects real mail silently
- Roughly \$13–15K a year to fix properly; ~\$84K over five years to stay as we are

FILEMAKER

Audit pack, 26 August

- 39 files · 258 tables · 16,015 fields · 4,148 scripts — measured, for the first time
- It works. Real port calls run on it daily. The domain model is the asset
- No proven restore, no development copy, one person able to maintain it
- 200–400 developer-days and \$40–150K to rewire in place; platform decision deferred

OPERATIONS

IT board, 15 September

- 88 open items, 34 “in progress” at once, 267 closed — effort is not the problem
- Incidents, data fixes, projects and platform decisions in one column, no dates
- Most desktop tickets trace to the email architecture
- Two platform decisions have sat in “waiting for” for months

None of the three asked the question that matters to ownership: what is the engine worth, to whom, and for how much longer — and what is it costing us to find out?

Cost figures are the assessments' own estimates, labelled as such in each document; none is a quote.

The reports — the shop window customers actually see

Product	Built from	Delivered by	Cadence	Condition
Elevator lineups — Mississippi River, Texas	FileMaker lineup files, updated by each office	Email list (iContact)	Daily	Aging
Full-agency export report	Sailed-vessel archive / Exports Master	Email attachment	Weekly	Aging
Cumulative export detail	Exports Master (507,551 records back to 2016)	Email attachment	Monthly	Aging
Quarterly and annual summaries	Same source, rolled up	Email attachment	Quarterly	Aging
Coal and other commodity reports	Dedicated FileMaker files	Email attachment	As required	Aging
Customer web portal	FileMaker WebDirect	Browser	Live	Map component broken; parked

These are the shop window. Free to the customer, they are how the company demonstrates its experience — superficial to a degree, and still the thing a principal sees every morning. Assembled by hand from FileMaker, sent as attachments through a mail system we are about to replace, in formats unchanged for years; nobody has asked customers which ones they open, and nobody has costed the hours they take.

“Aging” is our own assessment. Cadence and delivery are as observed; the inventory in block 2 replaces this table.

What we send for free, the market now sends better

What is changing outside the building

- **USDA now publishes interactive grain transportation and export dashboards** — weekly, public, free, and better formatted than what we send
- **Commercial data vendors** sell vessel tracking, port lineups and manifest data by subscription to anyone
- **Customers have analysts** — traders and elevators increasingly build their own views from the same public feeds
- **Assembly is no longer the skill** — software that compiles a lineup from a feed in seconds is now ordinary

What it means for the engine

- **A free report that repeats public data stops demonstrating anything** the day the public version is better — and that day is close
- **What survives is what only an agent on the dock knows:** the berth, the wait, the survey result, the reason for the delay, the relationship
- **The engine is optimised for the first kind of report** and has no way to capture or deliver the second
- **So each hour spent maintaining it as-is buys less** than the hour before — the definition of diminishing returns

The value these systems added was real and it is diminishing quickly. Not because they broke — because the world caught up. The pace of the technology and the administrative burden of producing the output make this an inflection point, not a maintenance problem.

Block 2 puts the USDA dashboards and two vendor products on the screen next to our own reports, so nobody has to take this on faith either.

The service is not in question — everything around it is

The whole scope is one realisation, not three problems

The core service — agency — is people, relationships and skill on the dock, and none of that is in question. Everything around it is: the presentation of the output, the tools the people work in, and the administrative burden of producing what the customer sees. The pace of the technology has made the gap visible. That is the inflection point.

Increase the value added

Output presented in the form the customer's business now runs on — timely, readable on a phone, carrying what only our agents know — so the free report keeps demonstrating experience.

Attract new business

The shop window is the first thing a prospective principal judges. A modern one wins nominations before anyone has met; a dated one loses them the same way.

Reduce the administrative burden

Every hour spent assembling a lineup by hand, hunting a mail attachment or fixing a laptop is an hour not spent on the dock or with a customer — and in a market that sets the price, it is margin.

Three outcomes, one programme. Any direction the working days choose is measured against these three — and the third one is the one the market lets us control.

When the market sets the price, you control three things

RED OCEAN

Where agency lives

- The market sets the price. Nobody in this trade names their own
- An ancient trade, run on customs and practices the whole world accepts — the same core service from every competitor
- Differentiating on price is a race to the bottom; differentiating on service is table stakes

PURPLE WATER

Where Blue Water can move

- Not a new market — a visibly different presence in the old one
- Presentation and speed of output; information carrying what only our agents know; a customer experience that looks like this decade
- Reached by taking cost and administration out of the engine and putting the time saved in front of the customer

BLUE OCEAN

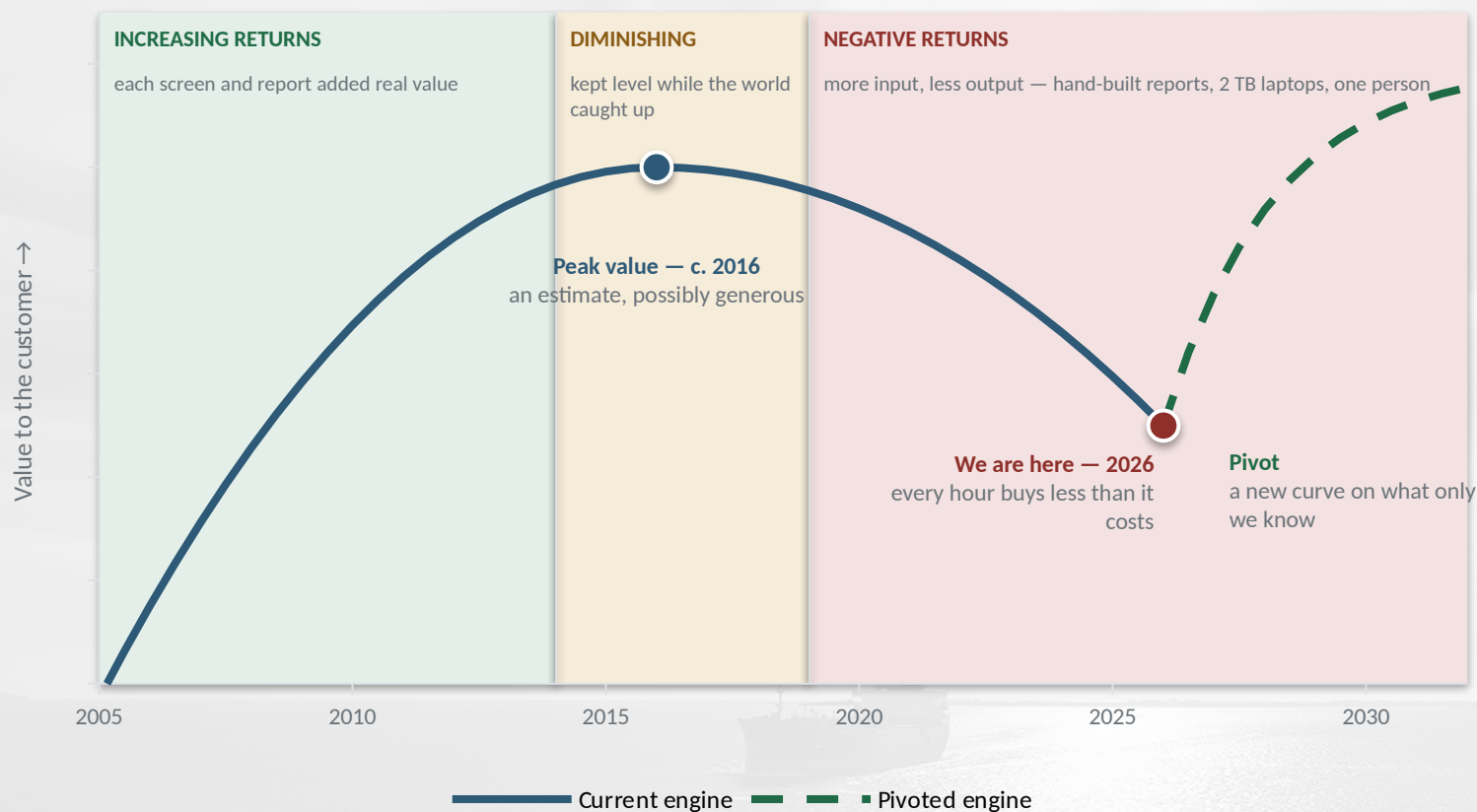
Rare — worth a look, not a bet

- A product nobody sells: our dock-level data combined with the public feeds, delivered as a service rather than an attachment
- Block 2 asks whether it exists; block 4 scores it. Nothing in this deck depends on finding it
- If it exists, it is built on the same modernised engine — which is why the pause comes first

Cost, cost and cost. When the price is set for you, margin is the only variable, and administration is where it leaks. Modernisation is a cost play first and a presentation play second — and the two are the same programme.

Red and blue ocean are the standard strategy terms; purple is ours — differentiated inside a market that sets the price.

Value peaked around 2016; we are in negative returns



Reading the curve

- Phase 1: built in-house by people who knew the trade, every screen and report moved the company forward. That was real, and it lasted a decade.
- Phase 2: additions kept it level while the outside world — public data, cheaper software, customers with analysts — caught up.
- Phase 3: since about 2019 more input has produced less output: the hours to make the reports, the laptops to hold the mail, the one person who can change anything.
- The audit's 200–400 developer-days holds the line — it stops the fall. It does not climb. Only the green curve climbs, and it starts from where we stand, not from the peak.

Illustrative curve, not measured data. The 2016 peak and the phase boundaries are the project manager's estimate; block 3 replaces them with the company's own cost and return figures.

The business questions — and the metrics that answer them

What does the engine cost, all in — per port call?

5-year total cost of ownership: licences, hardware, the person, the contractor, the laptops bought for mail, the hours lost — divided by the calls it serves

TCO

What do the reports cost to produce — and what do they win?

Hours per issue across every office, against the retention and new business they visibly support

Cost-to-serve

What does a day down cost?

3 August: internet, email and FileMaker off together; staff sent home. Multiply by the number of such days

Cost of downtime

What is a lost decade of records worth?

One server, one building, no proven restore, no off-site copy, hurricane season

Revenue at risk

What would a pivot cost, and when does it pay back?

The green curve, priced: people, data, delivery — against the blue curve, priced the same way

Payback period

What do customers value that only we can give?

Not a survey — five conversations with principals and elevators about what they read, what they would miss, and what would win the next nomination

Value to customer

These are business questions, not IT questions — which is why IT cannot answer them alone, and why the working days need finance, strategy and operations in the room.

Enough to know the stakes — not enough to decide

\$13.5–15.5K

per year: email done properly (M365 Premium + anti-fraud layer)

~\$84K

five years of staying as we are — buying no suite, no files, no archive, no security

\$40–150K

cash, plus 200–400 developer-days, to rewire FileMaker in place (estimate, not a quote)

\$550K–1.1M

per year of productivity lost to the systems, at 15–30% of the workday (public benchmark, not our payroll)

1 day

company-wide outage on 3 August — staff sent home; the cost of that day has never been calculated

~\$548K

requested and not received, visible in the disbursement data — a money trail the audit surfaced, to be verified

What is missing is the other side of the ledger. We know roughly what the engine costs to fix and what it costs to leave alone. We do not know what it earns, what the reports are worth to a customer, or what a pivot would cost. Block 3 is where those numbers get built — by accounting and operations, with the assessments as inputs.

Sources: email case Rev 5 §9–10; audit ownership recommendation §5; issues log #001, #003. Each figure is labelled in its source as measured, estimate or benchmark.

Pause · Reset · Strategy · Plan

PAUSE

Now

Stop discretionary spend and feature work on every part of the engine. Keep only safety work and day-to-day support. Nothing new starts until the plan is signed.



RESET

Early October

One programme, one board, one folder, one owner. All the material — three assessments, the board, the reports, the numbers — in one pack. Customer conversations and the TCO build happen here, before anyone sits down.



STRATEGY

Mid October · 3 days

A mini team — strategy, finance, project management — spends a few days together and works through all of it: the engine as-is, the market, the economics, the options. SWOT, TCO, vendor evaluations, weighted scoring.



PLAN

November

One consolidated plan with timelines and budgets, presented to ownership. Ownership agrees, adjusts or redirects; sign-off by mid-November; execution from then, on whichever curve was chosen.

Eight weeks. The cost of the pause is two months of features nobody has asked for. The cost of not pausing is another year of piecemeal work on the flat part of the curve, and a platform decision taken by default.

Between us we have strategy, finance and project management. Producing the analysis is no longer the constraint — people's time and imagination are.

What stops, and what does not

STOPS

- New FileMaker features, layouts and dashboards — the request queue is frozen, not deleted
- Plugin and version upgrades that are not security fixes
- Laptops, drives and storage bought to hold email
- The website rebuild and the Laravel migration
- New software subscriptions — password manager, mail client platforms, proposals: all move to the Decide queue for block 4
- Network kit beyond emergency repair, until the platform answer says what each office needs
- Any new assessment, audit or consultant engagement

CONTINUES

- **The 1 October server:** install, the first proven restore, the sandbox, an off-site copy — the audit's Phase 0, required under every future
- **Gateway from reject to quarantine**, so real mail stops being lost silently
- **POP → IMAP cleanup and server-side noise filters** — cost nothing, remove tickets
- **The three admin logins** — mail server, gateway, FileMaker Server
- **Day-to-day support** through one door, in a support window, three things in progress at most
- **Fixes for a stopped operation** — always, through the sandbox once it exists
- **The reports keep going out** exactly as they are; nothing changes for a customer during the pause

The line between the columns: does it make the company safer, or does it make the engine bigger? Safer continues. Bigger waits.

One programme, one board, one pack, one set of roles

One programme

The Engine programme, three pillars — email, FileMaker, reports — on one foundation of network and support. No pillar has its own plan; the programme has one.

One board

Four queues instead of one pile: Run (today's incidents) · Fix (weekly FileMaker batch) · Build (three active, max) · Decide (ownership, monthly). A label legend. Nothing enters except through the intake form.

One pack

All the material is now in one folder. Before the working days it becomes one reading pack: the three assessments' summaries, the issues log, the board, the report inventory, and the numbers we already hold.

One set of roles

Ownership decides platform, money and policy. The project manager owns sequence, calendar and the pack. IT executes and advises. Operations managers own what the reports must do. Accounting owns the numbers.

The consolidation of the folders is already done; the board re-lay and the reading pack are the first two weeks of October.

A mini team, three days, four blocks, one output each

1

The engine as-is

Day 1 • morning

Inputs: The three assessments, the issues log, the board — presented by their authors, questioned by the team

Output: A single agreed statement of fact. Disagreements logged, not argued

2

The market and the customer

Day 1 • afternoon

Inputs: The report inventory; USDA's dashboards and two vendor products on screen next to ours; the five customer conversations, reported back

Output: What customers value, what is commoditised, what only we can supply — and whether any blue water exists

3

The economics

Day 2

Inputs: TCO of today's engine, built by finance beforehand; the cost of each direction; cost-to-serve per port call; vendor evaluations

Output: One set of numbers everybody accepts — or the specific disagreement about them

4

Options and the plan

Day 3

Inputs: SWOT finalised; the directions scored against criteria written in block 1; the frozen request queue dispositioned; timelines and budgets drafted

Output: The consolidated plan, ready to put in front of ownership

The team: strategy • finance • project management (chair). IT and one operations manager per region join for blocks 1 and 2. The pack is read before day 1; no block opens with a presentation longer than twenty minutes.

Standard business models — chosen for what each one answers

SWOT

Where do we stand?

Strengths and weaknesses of the engine; opportunities and threats outside it. A starter draft is on the next slide — to be torn up in block 4.

Total cost of ownership, 5-year

What does it really cost?

Everything the engine consumes: licences, hardware, people, contractors, the hours lost. Today's engine and each option, on the same basis.

Cost-to-return and payback

Is it worth it?

For each direction: what it costs against what it returns — retention, pricing, new revenue, hours recovered — and when the return overtakes the cost.

Build • buy • partner

Who should do it?

For each part of the engine: build it ourselves, buy it off the shelf, or partner for it. Accounting already answered this once — Intacct — and it worked.

Weighted scoring, criteria first

How do we choose fairly?

The audit's own method: write the criteria before scoring the options, so the answer cannot be fitted to a preference. Block 1 writes them; block 4 scores.

Risk register

What could go wrong?

For the chosen direction and for doing nothing — stated as plainly as each other, with owners.

No framework is the answer. Each is a way of making sure a question gets asked. The audit's scored rubric is the model — it worked.

Drawn from what we already hold — block 4 tears it up

STRENGTHS

- Twenty years of agency expertise encoded in the data model — vessel, port call, principal, laycan, berth, cargo
- A properly built CRM: 8,495 companies, 6,744 contacts, audit-logged
- A decade of operating data — 507,551 export records — that nobody else holds
- Customer relationships and the skill of the agents; the engine serves them, not the reverse
- Accounting already migrated to Intacct by API — the engine can integrate when asked to

WEAKNESSES

- One person able to maintain the engine; no build documentation; no version history
- No proven restore; live file doubles as the development environment
- Email on end-of-life hardware; POP scatters the only copy across 2 TB laptops; no archive or hold
- Reports assembled by hand, sent as attachments, unchanged for years, unmeasured
- No standards — every office network, every laptop, every request is bespoke

OPPORTUNITIES

- A modern suite lays the foundation in one move: files, archive, shared mailboxes, security
- Own dock-level data plus public feeds → reports a customer cannot get from USDA or a vendor
- A sandbox makes change safe for the first time — and makes a second developer possible
- Purple water: in a market that sets the price, presentation and speed of output are the differentiators left
- All the material is in one place; the company can, for the first time, describe its own engine

THREATS

- USDA's free interactive dashboards and commercial data vendors — our reports repeat what they publish
- Wire-fraud email: a spoofed instruction is the loss that ends relationships
- One server, one building, Gulf coast, no off-site copy — hurricane season every year
- The one person leaves, or the contractor's start date arrives with no scope
- The market sets the price — margin is cost, and every hour of administration is margin given away

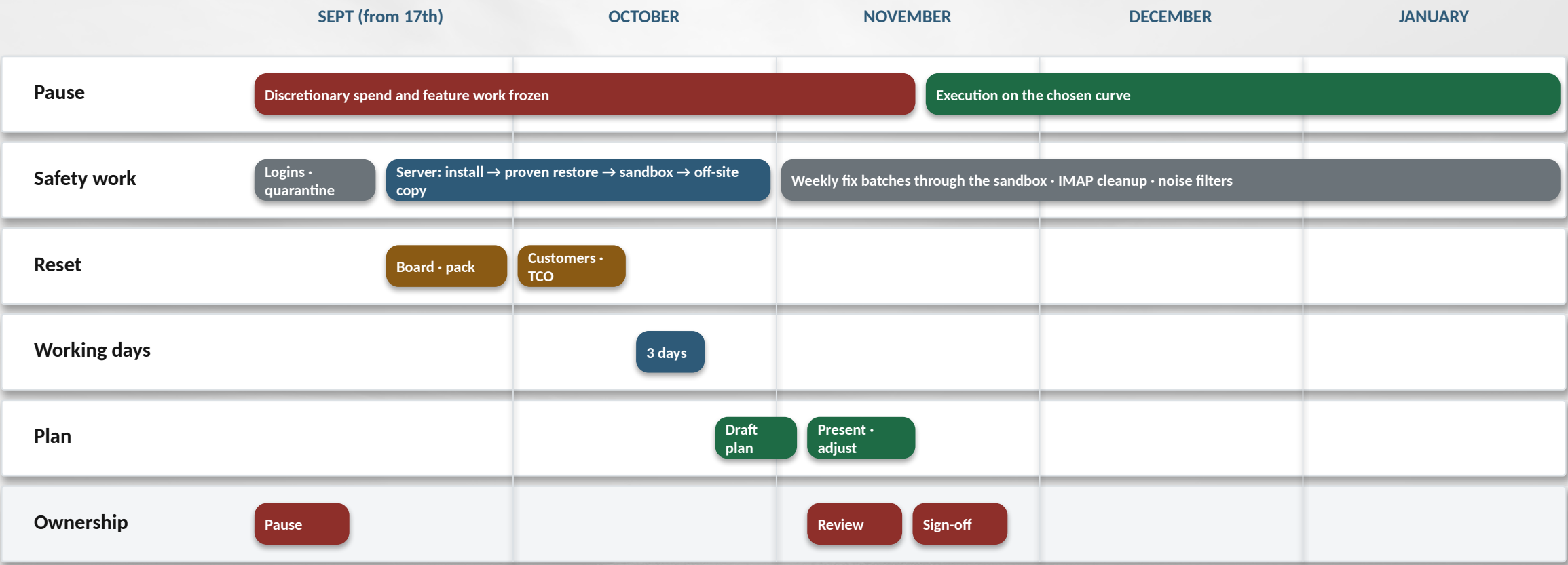
Every line traces to one of the three assessments or the issues log. Nothing here is new information — it has simply never been on one page.

Four directions — safety work first, then they diverge

A	Stabilise and modernise in place	Modern email suite; FileMaker rewired in place over 18–30 months; reports refreshed in format but not in kind.	Lowest risk. Stays on the blue curve. The audit's platform recommendation — and its honest limit.
B	Stabilise and pivot the reports	Same foundation, but the reports become a product: dock-level data the agents already capture, combined with public feeds, delivered on a platform rather than by attachment.	The green curve. Needs a product owner from operations and a data path out of FileMaker. Highest return if customers value it — block 2 tells us.
C	Stabilise and buy	Modern suite plus a commercial agency platform; FileMaker retired over time; reports from the vendor's tooling.	Not yet assessed by anyone — the audit says so. Real cost of migration and retraining ~60 staff. block 3 prices it.
D	Stabilise and outsource the run	Managed service for email, network and desktop; in-house effort concentrated on FileMaker and the reports.	Directly addresses the one-person risk. Can combine with A or B. Cheapest to test — a quote.
Not a menu of four. The likely answer combines them — B on top of A's foundation, with D taking the run work. Block 4 scores each part, not each letter.			

Scored on cost-to-serve first — the three C's — and on presentation second. The audit scored A-D for the platform alone; this widens the lens to the whole engine.

Pause now, plan to ownership in November, then execute



Dates are proposals; the only fixed one is the server. If the working days slip, everything after them slips — the pause does not extend on its own.

Stated as plainly as the risks of not pausing

Something breaks while we think

A server, a mailbox, a report that stops going out

→ Safety work does not pause. The restore, the sandbox and the off-site copy come first, before the working days

The pause becomes permanent

Two months becomes six; the freeze outlives its purpose

→ The working days have dates and outputs; sign-off is mid-November. If it slips, the freeze is reviewed, not extended

The working days become a complaints forum

Three days of what is wrong, nothing decided

→ Materials first; block 1 fixes the facts; a chair; criteria written before options are scored

Customers notice the reports decay

Nothing changes for them during the pause — which is the problem

→ The customer conversations happen in the reset weeks. That is the first time in years anyone has asked them, and it can only help

The one person reads this as a verdict

The person carrying the engine hears 'diminishing returns' as a judgement

→ It is the opposite. No one person could hold this, and the wider organisation cannot sustain piecemeal. The plan exists so that nobody has to

2

Agency Platform

The port call as the pipeline

A concept for the port-call record the audit found missing: eight stages from nomination to settlement, with port operations, accounting and forwarding as parallel tracks.

Today, and what one record per port call changes

TODAY

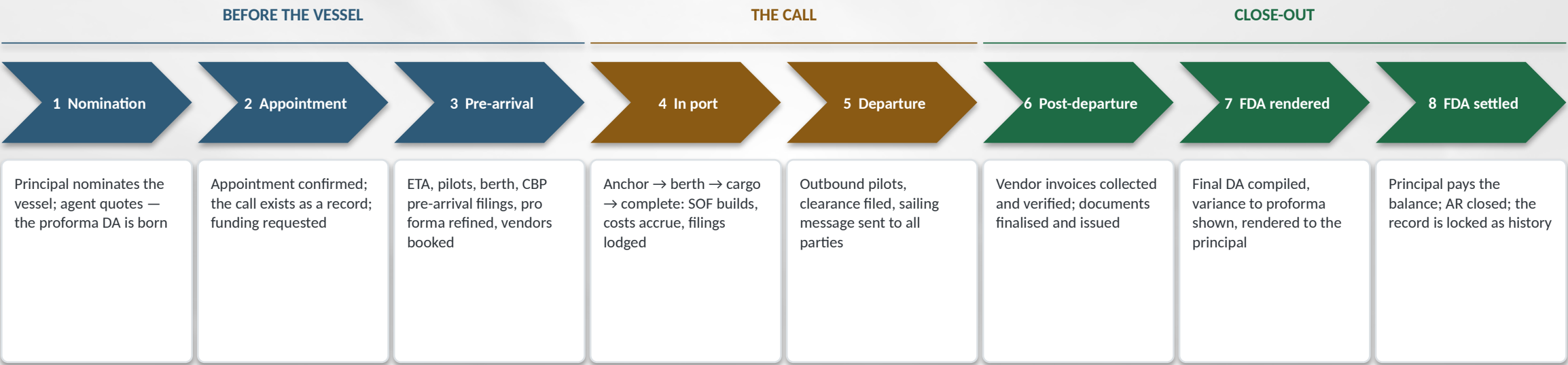
- **Hundreds of emails a day per agent** — orders, confirmations, updates, invoices, all in one inbox
- **The port call has no single identity** — it lives in a FileMaker record, a mailbox, a spreadsheet and a head, and the audit measured the gap
- **Disbursement accounts built by hand** — estimate, funding, actuals and settlement in separate places
- **Nothing connects** — vessel tracking, email, accounting, documents are separate systems
- **Tribal knowledge** — the critical detail is in someone's memory, not the record
- **No visibility for the principal** — 'where's my DA?' is a phone call

ONE RECORD

- **One port call, one status, one screen** — every call by stage, port and vessel
- **Eight stages, three tracks** — port operations, accounting and forwarding each with their own tasks, on the same record
- **Checklists generated per call type** — assigned, with deadlines; nothing falls through
- **The DA tracked live** — proforma → funding → actuals → FDA → settlement
- **A principal portal** — status, FDA approval, funding, documents, without a phone call
- **Everything searchable and auditable** — nothing lives only in email or a spreadsheet

Left column reads the same as the email case, the FileMaker audit and the issues log — because it is the same problem seen from the port call.

Eight stages — the whole life of a port call



Why the stages matter more than the screens

A port call with one governed status is what the FileMaker audit found the platform does not have: today a call is 'sailed' when a script moves it, 'billed' when accounting says so, and 'done' when the agent stops thinking about it. Eight named stages, each with an entry and exit condition, give every office, every report and every principal the same answer to 'where is this vessel?' — and every task, cost and document a place to hang.

Stages are the owner's own eight; the March concept used nine. Entry and exit conditions are for the operations managers to write.

One record, three tracks running in parallel

	1 Nomination	2 Appointment	3 Pre-arrival	4 In port	5 Departure	6 Post-departure	7 FDA rendered	8 FDA settled
PORT OPS	Receive nomination; quote; vessel particulars	Confirm; open the call; berth & terminal liaison	ETA/NOR watch; pilots, tugs, linesmen; CBP pre-arrival	Anchor, berth, cargo ops, SOF, delays, surveys, crew	Outbound pilots; sailing message; SOF sign-off	SOF & NOR issued; delay statement; vendor queries	Support FDA queries from the principal	Call archived; vessel history updated
ACCOUNTING	Proforma DA: pilotage, towage, dockage, stevedoring, fee	Funding request; wire tracked; short-fund alert	Proforma refined; vendors' rates confirmed	Costs accrue live: estimated → accrued → invoiced	Interim funding if burn exceeds balance	Invoices verified and approved; variance building	FDA compiled; variance report; agency fee; rendered	Settlement invoiced; AR aged 30/60/90; paid; closed
FORWARDING	Cargo & documentary requirements identified	Shipper/receiver contacts; document plan	Manifest, entry and export declarations prepared	B/Ls, mate's receipts, certificates as cargo works	Clearance lodged; B/Ls issued; documents released	Certificates, surveys, corrections; FF invoice raised	Forwarding charges in the FDA or billed separately	Document set archived with the call

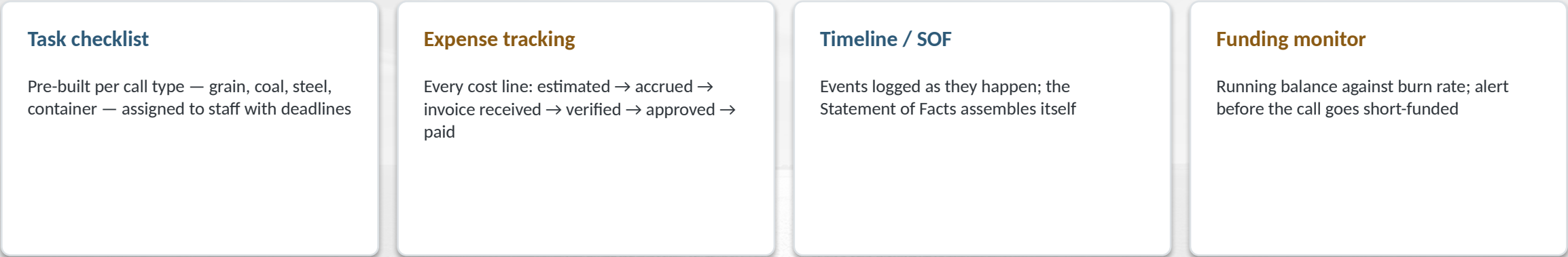
Same record, three owners, three checklists. A stage cannot close until each track has cleared its exit conditions — that is the whole discipline.

Cell contents are a first draft from the FileMaker file inventory and the March concept; the forwarding track in particular needs the forwarding team to correct it.

In port is where the record earns its keep



What the record does on its own while the agent is on the dock



The four sub-stages are how every agent already thinks about a call; the record simply names them.

The disbursement account is the backbone of every call

1	Proforma DA	Agent estimates all costs before arrival — pilotage, towage, dockage, stevedoring, agency fee — and sends it to the principal for approval.	Stages 1–3
2	Funding request	Principal wires funds against the estimate. Every receipt tracked; running balance shown; short-funding flagged before it bites.	Stages 2–4
3	Live expense tracking	As vendor invoices arrive, each line moves: estimated → accrued → invoice received → verified → approved → paid.	Stages 4–6
4	Final DA	All invoices in; actuals compiled; proforma-to-actual variance shown; agency fee calculated; FDA rendered.	Stage 7
5	Settlement	Settlement = FDA less funds received. AR aged 30/60/90; reminders automatic; paid; the record locks.	Stage 8

Proforma accuracy becomes a number. Estimate-to-actual trending by port, vessel type and cargo — the audit's 'money trail' answered on every call, not once.

This is the accounting track of the three-track slide, expanded. Intacct remains the ledger; the record feeds it, as FileMaker does today.

What each track — and the principal — sees

OPERATIONS	ACCOUNTING	FORWARDING	PRINCIPAL PORTAL
Port call dashboard every active call by stage, port, vessel	Disbursement accounts proforma → actuals → FDA, line by line	Document set per call manifest, entries, B/Ls, certificates	Port call status their vessels, current stage, live
Task checklists generated per call type, assigned, dated	Funding & settlement wires, running balance, settlement invoicing	Filing status lodged, accepted, released — per authority	FDA review & approval approve or query online
Timeline / SOF events logged live; SOF builds itself	AR / AP aging, vendor payments, principal collections	Forwarding invoices raised on the call or billed separately	Documents NOR, SOF, invoices, surveys in one place
Vessel & organisation registry particulars, principals, vendors	Proforma accuracy estimate vs actual by port, vessel, cargo	Cargo & party registry shippers, receivers, notify parties	Funding status wired, owed, settled
Shared: document storage · invoice OCR · search · notifications · audit trail · multi-office — and the reports, read from the same record.			

The March concept had three columns; forwarding is added because it is a track of its own in this company.

The concept against the FileMaker audit and the working days

What the audit already established

- The port call has no single identity or governed status — the structural finding behind most others
- Repeating things are numbered columns (BERTH1...BERTH7) — an eighth berth is a development project
- The domain model is the asset; the customer module is sound; accounting already left cleanly by API
- Every direction — stay, strangle, rebuild — starts with the same rewire of the port-call record

What this concept adds

- The target shape of that record, in the language of the people who use it — eight stages, three tracks
- A checklist and DA discipline that can be applied inside FileMaker, in a new build, or in a bought product
- A principal-facing layer the current platform does not have, and the reports are about to need
- A scoring basis for directions A-D: which gets closest to this, at what cost to serve

NOW

Foundation

Eight-stage workflow · DA management · checklists and timelines · vessel and organisation registry · documents and search

NEXT

Automation

Invoice OCR · principal portal · funding alerts and AR tracking · proforma-accuracy learning · multi-office

LATER

Intelligence

Cost analytics by port, cargo, vessel · fee estimation engine · BlueIQ data integration · mobile for field agents

Roadmap tiers from the March concept, re-pointed at Blue Water. Whether the vehicle is FileMaker, a new build or a product is exactly what block 4 decides.

CHAPTER 3

3

BlueIQ

One place for all data, all reports

The reports as a product — direction B made concrete. A proven pipeline, re-pointed at Blue Water's own data and Blue Water's own reports.

Raw records in, every report out

INGEST

Our own data and the public feeds

- FileMaker port calls, vessels, cargo, disbursements
- Exports master — 507,551 records back to 2016
- Office lineups, as the clerks record them today
- CBP entrances and clearances; ocean manifests
- River traffic (MRTIS), FGIS grain inspections, USDA
- The vessel register — 52,000 vessels worldwide

RESOLVE

One spine, one row per port call

- Deduplicate and clean — the prototype removed 11% junk
- Enrich from dictionaries: vessel type, agent, port, zone, terminal, cargo
- Sequence calls into voyages; use draft change to prove load vs discharge
- Cross-reference the sources by IMO, date and port
- Lock commodities; run integrity checks after every step
- Our dock-level data — berth, wait, delay, survey — joins here

DELIVER

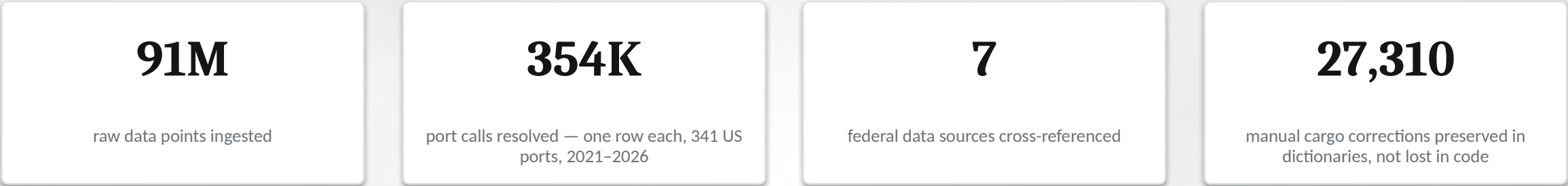
Every report from the same spine

- Daily elevator lineups — Mississippi River, Texas
- Weekly, monthly, quarterly and annual export reports
- Commodity reports — grain, coal, steel, all bulk
- Port market profiles and agency market share
- The principal portal — their vessels, live
- Fee estimation and proforma accuracy

The difference from today: the reports stop being assembled by hand from FileMaker and sent as attachments. They are generated from one resolved record, and they carry what only we know.

Middle column is the prototype's six-step pipeline; left and right columns are re-pointed at Blue Water's data and Blue Water's reports.

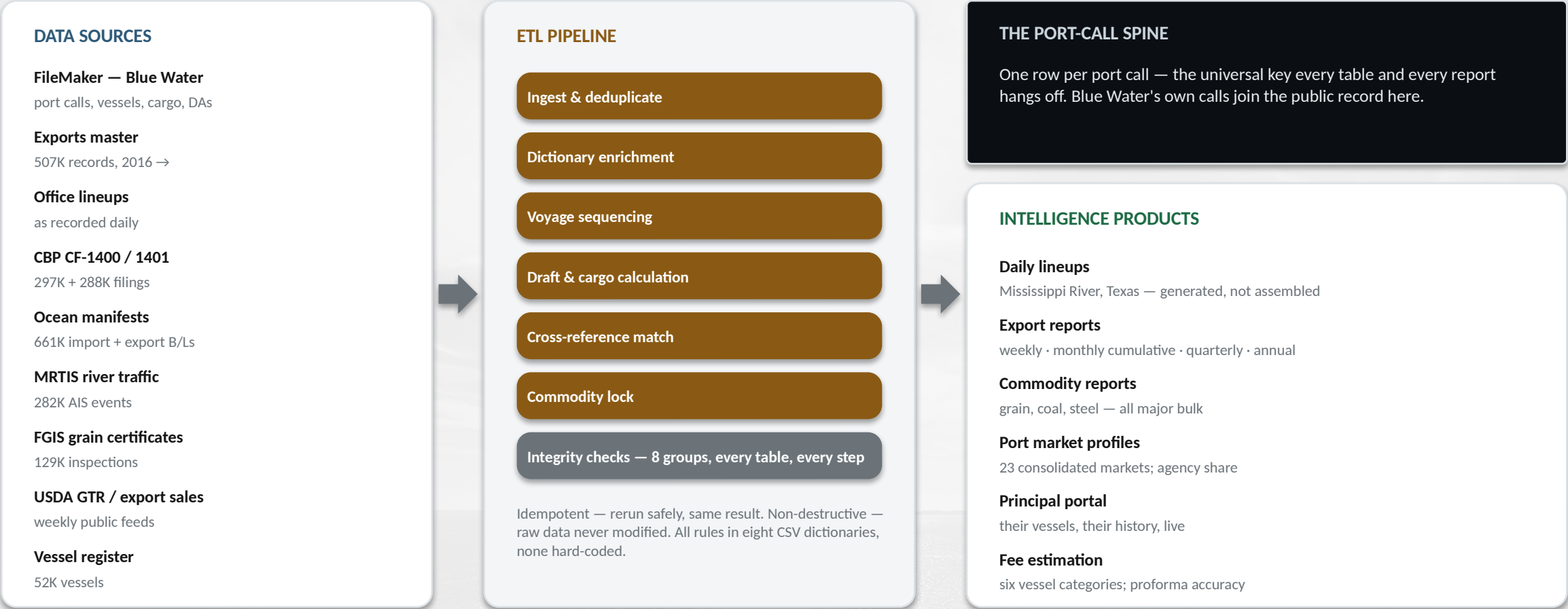
The engine behind it was built and run in March 2026



1	Raw records come in	CBP entrance and clearance filings, ocean manifests, river traffic, grain inspection certificates, the vessel register
2	Deduplicate and clean	318K records → 282K after removing 11% junk — duplicates, test entries, incomplete filings
3	Enrich from dictionaries	Eight lookups per record: vessel type, agent roll-up, port normalisation, zone, terminal, cargo class
4	Build voyages, calculate cargo	42,745 voyages sequenced; draft change — physics — decides load versus discharge
5	Cross-reference the sources	River traffic ↔ CBP ↔ manifests linked by IMO, date and port — 19,513 crosswalk links, physics-validated
6	Resolve and deliver	354,302 port calls with traceable cargo, agent, terminal and fee data — ready for reports and dashboards

Prototype built AI-assisted by W. Davis, ~120 hours against an estimated ~2,000 by traditional methods. Figures are the prototype's own; none has yet been run on Blue Water's data.

Sources → pipeline → spine → products



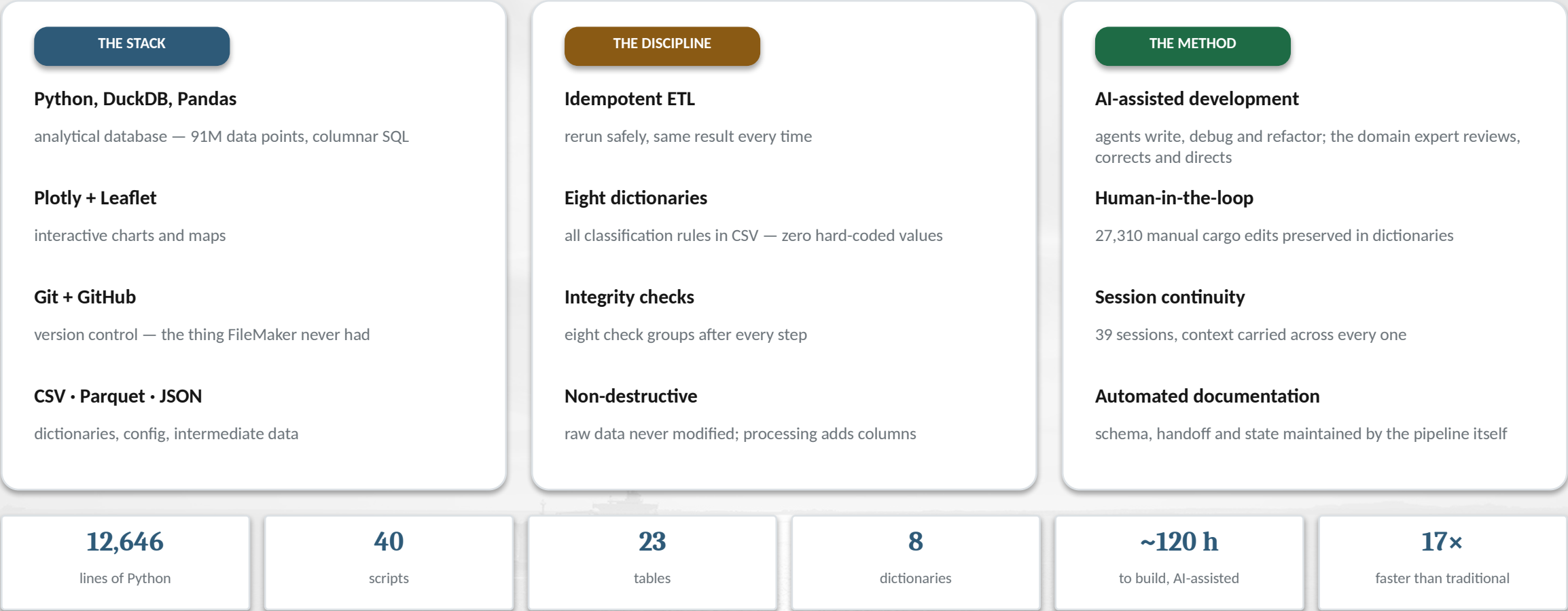
Sources in the left column marked Blue Water are new; the rest ran in the prototype. Product list is the current report inventory, re-pointed at the spine.

The same products, produced and delivered differently

	Today	With BlueIQ
How they are made	Assembled by hand from FileMaker finds and exports; a morning of a clerk's time per issue	Generated from the spine on a schedule; the clerk reviews and adds what the dock knows
Where the data comes from	Our own records only, keyed by hand	Our own records joined to the public feeds — USDA, CBP, river traffic, manifests
What they contain	Largely what USDA and the vendors now publish for free	The public picture plus dock-level fact: berth, wait, delay, survey, the reason
How they arrive	Email attachment from one sender via a list server	Portal and email; consistent format; readable on a phone; archived and searchable
How they look	Unchanged for years	One design system across every report — the shop window in this decade
What they cost	Unmeasured hours across every office	Measured: generation is cheap, review is the agent's judgement — cost to serve falls

Row three is the purple-water row: the public picture is table stakes; the dock-level fact is what only an agent can add.

Domain expertise drives; AI executes and validates



Why it matters to the engine: this is the opposite of the FileMaker build — versioned, documented, rule-driven, re-runnable, and not dependent on one person's memory.

Pilot on our own data; build only if customers want it

PILOT

Q1 2027 • 8–10 weeks

- Blue Water port calls through the six steps; measure the join
- One report — the Mississippi River lineup — generated end to end
- Dock-level fields defined with operations; captured on the call
- Side-by-side with today's version for five customers

BUILD

2027

- All export and commodity reports moved onto the spine
- Design system across every report; portal for principals
- Scheduled daily pipeline; containerised; cloud hosted
- Data path out of FileMaker — the audit's Q-003 answered

RUN

2028 →

- Credentialed access; two-factor; audit trail
- AI-assisted matching — vessel names, cargo classification
- Fee estimation and proforma accuracy feeding the DA
- The shop window becomes a product line — priced or not

Where it sits in the engine. BlueIQ is direction B: the reports as a product on top of direction A's foundation. It needs three things the pause is already securing — a sandbox to read FileMaker safely, a modern mail and file platform to deliver through, and the customer conversations to prove anyone wants it. None of it starts before block 4.

Pilot scope is deliberately one report and five customers — the cheapest possible test of the purple-water thesis.

4

Website & Portal

A first read, and what to review

bluewatershipping.com and the Pilotsheet portal from the outside: what is there, what the security scan says, the customer-access question, and a concept direction for a separate session.

A 1979 agency's front door, built for the web of 2005

6

regional sections — Pacific, Mississippi River, Mobile, Texas, Norfolk, Baltimore

PHP

one hand-built page per menu item; no content system detected

2

operational links: Pilotsheet (portal) and Locate Vessel

1990

the year the Technology page still dates the company's platform choice from

What a visitor finds

- **The right message:** 24-hour agency at all US ports; bulk grain, oilseeds, fertiliser, steel, ores, coal, pet coke, LNG; forwarding; AMS and eNOA/D
- **The right structure:** offices, team by region, port maps, port information, weather — an operational site, not a brochure
- **The wrong decade:** team and 'family' pages, a Mac-network story from 1990, port pages that read as static text — and every one of them maintained by hand
- **No route to the shop window:** no lineups, no reports, no subscription, no sign-in for a principal — the things customers actually want from us are not here

Why it belongs in this package

The site is the first thing a prospective principal sees and the only thing most of them ever see. It is also the natural home for the shop window — the lineups, the reports, the portal — once BlueIQ generates them. Today it is maintained the way the reports are: by hand, by one person, in code nobody else can edit. The Trello board already carries 'update website code to Laravel' and 'find a new map for WebDirect', both parked. It is part of the engine, and it should be reviewed with it.

External read of bluewatershipping.com on 18 September 2026 — public pages only; no access to the code or the server.

Two public endpoints, two grades, two hosts

	www.bluewatershipping.com	bluewater.pro — Pilotsheet portal
Security-headers grade	D	C
Enforces HTTPS (HSTS)	Missing	Present — one year, subdomains
Content Security Policy	Missing	Missing
Clickjacking protection	Missing	Present
Referrer / permissions policy	Missing	Missing
Server advertised	nginx, on a small cloud VPS	Apache — FileMaker WebDirect behind it; session cookie without SameSite
Served from	A hosting-provider address	An office-connection address — production FileMaker Server exposed directly from Metairie (inference)
Build	Hand-built PHP, page per file, no CMS; 'migrate to Laravel' parked on the board	FileMaker WebDirect — the same platform the audit describes

What this is and is not. A header scan and a read of public pages — the cheapest possible look. It is not a penetration test, and nothing here has been checked against the code or the server. The full audit is the separate session.

Header scans 18 Sep 2026 (securityheaders.com). 'Served from' is inferred from the address block each host resolves to; confirm with IT.

One door for staff and principals — onto production

How it works today, as far as the outside can tell

- The website's 'Pilotsheet' link goes to FileMaker WebDirect on bluewater.pro — the production operations file, in a browser
- The same address appears to serve staff and any customer given a login; there is no separate customer tier
- The map component is broken and the fix is parked ('find a new map for WebDirect'); the vessel locator is a separate PHP search
- WebDirect sessions count against server licensing and load — customers browsing compete with agents working

Questions for the working days

- Who has a portal login today — which principals, which staff, and who issues and revokes them?
- What can a customer see and change? Their own vessels only, or more? Has anyone tested it as a customer?
- Is the file behind WebDirect the same live file the audit calls the development environment?
- Is there two-factor, a session limit, an access log — and who reads it?

Where it should end up

The principal portal in chapter 2 and the delivery layer in chapter 3 are the same thing seen from two sides: a customer-facing tier, separate from production, with its own identity and two-factor, showing a principal their vessels, their FDA, their funding and their reports. The website is its front door. Until then, the minimum is to know who holds a key and to put the sandbox rule between them and the live file.

Observations are external; the questions are for IT and operations to answer in block 1. Nothing here has been tested with a login.

The front door to the shop window

WHAT IT BECOMES

- **The public face of the service:** ports, offices, people, capability — current, phone-first, maintained without a developer
- **The front door to the portal:** one sign-in, a customer tier separate from production, two-factor
- **The shop window, live:** lineups, port information, weather and the reports published from BlueIQ, behind sign-in where they should be
- **Hosted properly:** managed platform, CDN and firewall in front, headers and certificates handled, nothing served from the office line

THE SEPARATE SESSION

- **Full external audit:** headers, certificates, DNS and mail records, stack, content inventory, accessibility, search visibility
- **Portal access review:** with IT — who, what, from where, logged how; the WebDirect licensing and load question
- **Concept:** page map, three or four wireframes, the customer-tier sign-in flow, and a build/buy/host recommendation
- **Output:** a chapter-4 replacement for this package and a costed line in the plan

For the pause: the website rebuild stays frozen with everything else. The one thing worth doing now is the portal access review — it costs nothing and it is a security question, not a design one.

The website is on the issues list from today: build, security headers, hosting, portal exposure, and the parked Laravel and map items.

WHAT THIS NEEDS

Pause now. A plan in front of ownership by November.

FROM THE THREE OF US

1 Three days in October, together

Strategy, finance and project management in one room with the pack read.
Dates fixed this week.

2 Own a piece each

Finance builds the TCO and cost-to-serve beforehand. Strategy owns the market block and the customer conversations. Project management owns the pack, the chair and the plan.

3 One consolidated plan

Timelines, budgets, owners — presented to ownership in early November, adjusted to their direction, signed off by mid-month.

FROM OWNERSHIP

1 Agree the pause, effective now

Discretionary IT spend and new feature work frozen until the plan is signed.
Safety work pre-approved and continuing.

2 The sandbox rule and the logins

No production FileMaker change outside the sandbox once it exists; the three admin logins handed over this week.

3 An hour in November

Review the plan, change what needs changing, sign it off. Four appearances in total across the calendar.

Nothing here commits the company to a vendor, a rebuild or a hire. It commits us to thinking once, together, at the right altitude — before striking ground-level targets again.